

Application Question (8881)

9. How far do you agree that online personal data collection brings about more benefits than harm?
Support your answer with reference to:

- the ideas and opinions from at least one of the reading passages
- examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society.

Structure	Response	Line	R, EX, EV
	The author in Passage 1 claims that “both the independent actions of the passengers and the constant streaming of their personal data produce swarm intelligence that is used to benefit everyone.” I agree that online personal data collection provides more benefits than harm, especially when this idea executed in the context of societies driven by technologically-advanced communication networks and hence it is largely applicable to Singapore where many are tech-savvy and constantly on their phones. Personal data collected from all these phones help in times of crisis. For example, when there is a train breakdown, many people start bringing this up on the internet, alerting everyone of the current situation that enables suitable measures to be rolled out such as free shuttle buses for people travelling. Additionally, during Covid 19, personal data collected from mobile devices can also help for contact tracing and help the government better tackle the Pandemic by putting any close contacts in quarantine. In fact, if we evaluate the constant streaming of personal data to produce swarm intelligence, we can see that this particularly true of Singapore because of our ‘kiasu’ mindset that makes us feel the need to document anything happening around us. This allows for effective and efficient collection of data that can be put to good use. In Singapore, the habit to critique everything also helps to allow for improvements in various aspects of society as there data are collected as feedback and suggestions.	5 10 15 20	
	However, online personal data collection also causes more harm than benefits in certain cases. As seen from Passage 2, the author states that “once your personal information is out there, there is really no way to stop it from being circulated or used.” In the context of Singapore, which is a highly digitised society, many things are shifting online, meaning that these things can be immortalised and kept on the internet forever. With the rise of social media platforms such as TikTok where you can easily post a 15 seconds video at any time, it could be highly dangerous as people are oblivious to their personal data being leaked and stolen. Personal data ranging from age, looks to content viewed or content posted are collected without our knowledge, which are then used to target advertisements at us or even sold to other companies. This leads to an endless cycle where our personal data is being passed around at the expense of our privacy and possibly even our safety. For example, the app TraceTogether by the Singapore Government meant for contact tracing collected personal data of Singaporeans that could also be	25 30 35 40	

	used in police investigations if needed. This breeches the privacy of Singaporeans and the personal data collected on us can no longer be returned. Hence seeing how vulnerable we are to getting our personal data collected, online personal data collection could potentially harm us in the long run as we no longer have a sense of privacy and security. Thus, online data protection does not always provide more benefits than harm.	45	
	Summing up, online data collection can be useful if the data collected is to be used to facilitate decision-making and follow-up actions by the masses and for the masses in dire situations. This, however, is still dependent on who decides on how and when such data collected online should be used. Hence we all have to be prepared for the eventual loss of privacy and the extent of such loss. And indeed we would more likely to be not in control of data once we shared online. The potential risk to harms hence is much graver than benefits.	50	
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Learning Points for MSN:

Learning Points for CU & Conclusion:

Assessment Component	You must show throughout the AQ for BAND 4 (10-12m):
<u>Requirements</u> [R]	Sustained focus on the requirements of the question; balanced response
<u>Explanation</u> [EX]	Cogent answer with very good understanding of the terms and issues raised by the passages
<u>Evaluation</u> [EV]	Convincing evaluation, making of judgements, and developing arguments to logical conclusions; elaboration and support through personal insight and experience, with apt illustration